

The trend of the seventies — People Power

In architecture as in everything else, fads come and go with bewildering speed. Glass buildings were in, now they're out (score one for the energy crisis), brick is back in.

One group, the so-called New York School, is busy reviving the pristine white buildings of the early modern movement, while others are plumping for shed roofs and woodsy siding. Throw-away, plug-in architecture takes a bow, gets cheered and is then hissed off the stage, supplanted by the gurus of recycling older buildings.

Underneath it all, there's more to architecture than such turbulent fashions, but the deeper ground swells aren't always so easy to see.

One such change has been gathering for a long time and now seems ready to take over as the central fact of architecture in the seventies. It's called citizen participation, and what it means is that the big decisions about the design of the man-made environment are passing out of the hands of the private developers and the government renewers and into the hands of the general public.

It's happening because, for some reason, enough people have decided that the quality of the environment is too important to leave to the experts.

So, in East Boston for example, you see one expert — the Port Authority — abandoning its runway extensions because some citizens convinced a judge that maybe there should be an environmental impact study. Shortly afterwards, of course, the Port also

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abandoned its executive director in favor of a setup that it claims will be responsive to guess who? The people! Robert Moses would vomit.

Or in the case of Park Plaza, you have the exhilarating sight of one government — the state — putting up money for a citizens group that is monitoring the efforts of another government — the city — to reshape a big chunk of downtown.

Here too, the environmental impact study is the arena in which the issues are being fought. Every time the BRA's environmental experts issue a document, the Citizen's Advisory Committee comes up with a counter blast. Environmental impact studies may be largely redundant and worthless as far as assessing a project, but they're wonderful as a wedge to let the public into the design process.

Maybe the best example around here, even one of the best in the country, is Harvard Square, which surely must be the most prayed over crossroads since Oedipus. So many people are walking around studying Harvard Square that they are creating additional congestion, a perfect example of Heisenberg's principle that you can't really study anything because the act of studying it always changes it.

One citizens group, the Harvard Square Task Force, is putting out a policy plan for the square; an MIT group is going around interviewing neighborhood

people to structure a policy; Harvard University has labored and is giving birth to a mouse in the form of a Long Range Plan that is one of the more constipated and noncommittal documents of our time; the Federal government, rumor holds, is desperately revising the Kennedy Library environmental impact statement so it won't come out too unfavorable; hearings are being held on the Red Line extension; battles are being waged over a proposed Dunkin' Donuts stand; and lots, lots more.

Public participation in all this frenzy is at an all-time high and it looks as if, soon, being a concerned citizen in Cambridge will be a fulltime job that will itself, perhaps, have to be delegated to specialists.

Just a few years ago, none of this could have happened. The fights to stop the highways helped change that. People found out that so-called entrenched power groups really depend almost entirely on citizen apathy and disorganization.

The problem now is to make all this involvement work. Places like Harvard Square are social laboratories, in which we're experimenting to find out how public participation in the design of the environment can be organized so that it's constructive, not obstructivist.

Somewhere between the autocratic developers and institutions of the past, and the mob rule that some people foresee in the present confusion, there ought to be a middle ground called democracy. Once again, we seem to be trying to define exactly what that is. Not a bad thought as we head into the Bicentennial.